6 LINES FOR THE FIRST MEETING OF A PROJECT, SO IT ENDS WITH OWNERS

What to put in a kickoff invite

Dennis · Sr PM at Microsoft · @dennisthinks_

1 Title the invite with what you leave with

”Kickoff” tells people to listen. ”Owners and first date” tells them to decide.

> DON’T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don’t say: “Project Atlas kickoff”
> Instead say: “Atlas: owners per workstream + first date”

The title is the outcome.

2 Cut the length in half and say why

A 60-minute kickoff gets a 60-minute deck. Thirty gets decisions.

> DON’T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don’t say: “Blocking 60 to be safe.”
> Instead say: “30 minutes. Context is in the doc; the meeting is for names.”

Half the time, context in the doc.

3 Send the one-pager two days before

A kickoff with the background inside it is a reading session with witnesses.

> DON’T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don’t say: “I’ll walk through the background on the call.”
> Instead say: “One-pager attached. Read it before; we start on the open questions.”

Pre-read or no kickoff.

4 Open with the three names you need

Say the decisions in the first sentence. People decide faster when they know what they’re deciding.

> DON’T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don’t say: “Let’s go around and introduce ourselves.”
> Instead say: “We leave with three owners: data, rollout, comms. Who’s taking data?”

Names first. Intros if there’s time.

5 End with a date someone said out loud

A kickoff with no first date is a meeting that happens again.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Let's follow up next week."
> Instead say: "First checkpoint: data model by the 14th. Priya said it, so it's hers."

A date, a name, said out loud.

6 The one-line invite body

This is the one on page 2. One line in the body tells each person why they're on it.

> DON'T SAY / INSTEAD SAY
> Don't say: "Kickoff for Atlas. Agenda to follow."
> Instead say: "You're on this to own one of three workstreams (data, rollout, comms). If that's not you, decline and tell me who."

Say why they're invited, and let the wrong people leave.

Check before you send it

- [ ] Does the title say what you leave with?
- [ ] Is it 30 minutes with the context in a doc?
- [ ] Did the one-pager go out two days before?
- [ ] Does your first sentence name the decisions?
- [ ] Did someone say a date out loud?